

Editorial Writing

Invitational A Meet • 2022



You are a reporter for the Leaguetown **Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School. From the given information, write an **editorial** as you would for the high school newspaper. Remember that as an editorial writer, you should support or oppose **policy or action**; you should not sermonize.

You have
45 minutes.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 800 students enrolled in grades 9-12. In the fall, the “devious lick” challenge went viral on TikTok. The challenge involved students going on TikTok to boast about stealing school equipment like soap dispensers, paper towel holders, microscopes, electronic whiteboards and other school items. The high school was not immune to the challenge. In September and October, several school bathrooms were vandalized. Students stole soap dispensers, bathroom doors and even the handles on the toilets. As a result, the administration closed two girls’ and two boys’ bathrooms. The student bathrooms near the cafeteria, the main office and near the gym remained open. The bathrooms in the gym also stayed open.

Because of district staff shortages and equipment shortages, the damaged bathrooms were not fixed until late December. All bathrooms have been repaired, but Principal Lucy Morningstar has not reopened them. She said several teachers and a group of students asked for those bathrooms to remain closed.

Not everyone agrees with this. The Student Council officers and a group of parents asked the administration to open all bathrooms for students.

Principal Morningstar said she hasn’t made a final decision about the bathrooms. To discuss the issue, she will hold a meeting with parents and students next Thursday at 7 p.m. in the school cafeteria. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed this Friday (the week before the Thursday meeting).

THOSE SUPPORTING THE CLOSURES

Fewer open bathrooms makes it easier for administrators to patrol the area to ensure no one is vandalizing anything. Fewer bathrooms make it more likely that an administrator is nearby, which helps students feel safer. Also, custodians have less to clean at the end of the day.

THOSE OPPOSING THE CLOSURES

Four closed bathrooms leads to overcrowding. Students are late to class because they have to walk farther for the open bathroom, and they often have to wait for a stall to be unoccupied. Also, some students who need to use the bathroom during class are missing more instruction because the bathroom closest to their classroom is closed.

■ LUCY MORNINGSTAR, principal

“I expected my administration and faculty to want to keep those repaired bathrooms closed. I didn’t expect students to make that request also. Several have. They told me they were intimidated to go into the closed bathrooms because of activity that was occurring there — vandalism, vaping, bad talking,

■ LUCY MORNINGSTAR (cont.)

and other infractions.

“We don’t need to reopen those bathrooms. Our school was built with too many bathrooms. My administrators and I have watched the bathroom situation closely since we closed those other bathrooms. Students rarely have to wait for a stall.

“Since closing those bathrooms, we have had no vandalism in any bathroom. My assistant principals also said that they have had a dramatic decrease in complaints of smoking or vaping in the bathrooms. I think that’s because we can monitor the open bathrooms more easily.”

■ LAURIE GERMANY, math teacher

“The four closed bathrooms were the least used bathrooms. The locations were not central to the main hallways in school, which is also why those are the bathrooms that were vandalized. I have only had a handful of students who have been tardy because of waiting for a bathroom. Most students are arriving on time without any issues. We don’t need to open those closed bathrooms. It will lead to more headaches.”

■ TAMIKA ELLIS, junior and Student Council treasurer

“I can’t believe this is even an issue. If the bathrooms have been repaired, open them. We don’t have enough open. In between classes, the bathrooms are packed. You can barely squeeze in. I usually just wait and ask to go during class, which stinks because then I miss class time.

“I don’t think students are stupid enough to vandalize the bathrooms again. Plus, we all would keep an eye on them. Every student has suffered because of the actions of a few.”

■ ROHAN OZA, sophomore

“I have three tardies in English because of bathroom lines. If I get one more, I get a detention. This is ridiculous. There isn’t one bathroom near my English class, so I have to walk all the way to the main office area. I pass two closed bathrooms on my way. Ms. Morningstar needs to reopen those bathrooms. We have all been punished enough.”

■ GRACE NGUYEN, parent of a freshman

“If the school didn’t plan on opening the bathrooms again, then why bother to repair them? The school could have saved quite a bit of money. The bathrooms need to be reopened. My daughter hates to use the bathroom at school now because they are all so crowded.”

■ SYBIL BROWN, freshman

“I prefer that we don’t have all of the bathrooms open. Before the administration closed some of the bathrooms, I hated going into them. Girls would vape or scream rude and profane things at me. Now, the bathrooms are filled with other students, so those mean girls can’t do anything. Plus, teachers and administrators are now always close by. I feel much safer with the four bathrooms closed. I hope they stay that way.”

■ ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Several teachers suggested turning at least one set of the closed restrooms into faculty restrooms. The only two faculty restrooms are located in the main office area.

DO NOT PASS OUT TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST**EDITORIAL WRITING/INVITATIONAL A • 2022****CONTEST TIPS AND SAMPLE EDITORIALS**

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critique/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Lead with a statement of the situation and then take a clear, definite staff stance. The situation is whether the school should reopen the four repaired bathrooms.
2. As a general rule, use third person. If you must use a pronoun, use first person plural (we, meaning "we, the newspaper staff"). Do not use first person singular (I, me, mine) or second person (you). Avoid unnecessary use of pronouns. Rather than "We believe the principal should...", write instead, "The principal should."
3. Don't waddle into the editorial. Get right to the point and, as a general rule, don't ask a lot of questions. An editorial should answer questions, not ask them. Above all, remember that your purpose is to make thoughtful, logical arguments in support of your position, not to engage in a tirade. The editorial should not be long — 450 words at the most. Although it's not recommended all the time, sometimes a writer could use a feature opening to grab the reader's attention and get them into the story.
4. Look for the future angle. Your paper comes out before the parent/student meeting.
5. Once you've stated your position/stance, the body of the story should support your stance and refute the opposition.
6. After the body of your editorial, complete the editorial with a specific solution.
7. Avoid direct quotes unless the quote adds substantially to the editorial. You can pull information from these quotes, as has been done here, but it's not necessary to attribute that information unless the person has a lot of credibility toward the story itself.
8. Watch for factual errors. Pay attention to minor details. Also, stay focused.
9. Don't clutter up the editorial with cliches or trite phrases such as "adults don't understand teens" or any variation thereof. Also, edit out the name of the school unless it is necessary for clarity. It isn't necessary to say "Leaguetown Independent School District" or "Leaguetown High School." Students know the name of the school. They don't need to be reminded.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/SUPPORTING

After four of the school's bathrooms were damaged as part of TikTok's "devious lick" challenge, the school closed the bathrooms to make necessary repairs. The repairs were completed in December, but Principal Lucy Morningstar has not reopened the bathrooms at the request of administrators, teachers and some students.

Morningstar will hold a student and parent meeting in the school cafeteria at 7 p.m. next Thursday to discuss the issue.

Parents and students should advocate for those bathrooms to be permanently closed to students.

The school has functioned fine without the four bathrooms. In fact, since those bathrooms were closed, none of the open bathrooms have been vandalized, and administrators say smoking and vaping have decreased dramatically. The school runs better with fewer bathrooms.

The open bathrooms are a little more crowded, but that is not a bad thing. It's much harder to bully a student or make bad choices in a crowded bathroom. Several students have told the principal that they feel safer with the four bathrooms closed.

Fewer bathrooms also make life easier for administrators and teachers. They have fewer places to monitor and more time to spend on improving the school. Custodians also have less to clean each evening.

Students who want the bathrooms open say they are late to class because of overcrowding in the bathrooms. This may happen from time to time, but there is an easy solution. The principal could add a minute or two to the passing period. This would allow students a little more time to use the bathroom or wait in a line if they had to.

Also, since the bathrooms have been repaired, the school could change two of the bathrooms to faculty restrooms. Currently, the only faculty restrooms are near the main office.

The current number of open bathrooms is working well for the school. No vandalism. Safer areas. It doesn't make sense to flush all of that away.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/OPPOSING

After four of the school's bathrooms were damaged as part of the TikTok "devious lick" challenge, the school closed the bathrooms to make necessary repairs. After months of delays, the repairs were completed in December, but Principal Lucy Morningstar still has not reopened the bathrooms.

This is ridiculous.

Morningstar agreed to hold a student and parent meeting in the school cafeteria at 7 p.m. next Thursday to discuss the issue. Students must show up and let her know they want the bathrooms reopened.

It makes no sense to spend the money to repair the bathrooms if they are never going to be used. That's wasting funds, and the school district can't afford to waste funds.

Besides that, the current bathrooms are overcrowded, and students are arriving late to class because of waiting in long lines at the bathrooms. Students are facing possible disciplinary consequences because of bathroom lines. That seems silly when four repaired bathrooms are ready for use.

Also, some students are choosing to wait to use the bathroom during class time to avoid the crowded bathrooms. This means students are missing instruction time when it is completely unnecessary.

The administration and teachers say it is easier to monitor the bathrooms with four of them closed. It probably is, but that is not a good enough reason to keep those four bathrooms closed. It would be even easier to monitor only one bathroom, but that is not logical or fair to students.

Administrators can ask coaches to help monitor the bathrooms, and they also can explain to students that they need to help monitor each other. Students have suffered enough with four bathrooms closed. They won't want to lose the bathrooms again.

Principal Morningstar should communicate her expectations for reopening the bathrooms and trust that the students can deliver.